

WILDLIFE & SPECIES

BILL 5 · WEAKER PROTECTION

Bill 5 and related changes roll back species-at-risk protections, environmental assessment, and public participation — clearing the way for development that communities and scientists have long opposed.

BILL 5**SPECIES AT RISK****SEZS**

BILL 5 — WHAT CHANGED

Ontario Nature, the David Suzuki Foundation, and legal experts have documented broad rollbacks.

- Species-at-risk habitat protections weakened — more projects can proceed with less scrutiny.
- Environmental assessment requirements reduced for categories of development.
- Public participation windows shortened; community objections are easier to dismiss.
- Ministerial discretion expanded — fewer independent checks on harmful projects.
- Petitions calling for repeal reflect widespread concern across Ontario communities.

SPECIAL ECONOMIC ZONES

SEZs can bundle land-use, environmental, and labour rules into fast-track development packages.

- Special economic zones may bypass normal municipal and environmental planning.
- Water, wildlife habitat, and farmland in zone boundaries face concentrated risk.
- Jobs promises are often overstated; environmental liabilities stay with the public.
- Once a zone is declared, local democratic control is permanently reduced.

WHY BIODIVERSITY MATTERS HERE

Ontario's species and ecosystems underpin farming, fishing, tourism, and climate resilience.

- Habitat loss is irreversible on human timescales — extinction is permanent.
- Weakened enforcement shifts costs to future generations and rural communities.
- Indigenous knowledge and stewardship are sidelined when participation rules shrink.
- Full issue page: protectont.ca/wildlife

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